Battle of Marengo
Swiss and Landsknecht mercenaries clash at Marengo in 1515. A short *katzbalger* sword can be seen raised in the foregound; it proved highly effective at close quarters.

The Landsknechts also formed elite *blutfahnen* (blood banner) units that made near-suicidal attacks on especially well-defended enemy positions. The arquebusiers who provided the Landsknechts' firepower did not need to be especially well trained. Indeed, one of the advantages of firearms was that almost anyone could be taught to use them, whatever their personal qualities; a pike or halberd, by contrast, required considerable strength to use.

> "IT WAS SO HOT THAT THE ARMOURED MEN NEARLY SUFFOCATED ... AND WHEN ONE WENT TO HELP THE OTHER BY LOOSENING THE ARMOUR HE WOULD BURN HIS FINGERS ON THE METAL."
>
> **NIKLAUS GULDI**, LANDSKNECHT SOLDIER, ON THE TUNIS EXPEDITION, 1535

STYLE AND VIOLENCE

Exactly how the Landsknechts developed their distinctive swaggering style of dress is not clear, although it seems to have been based on the costume of their greatest rivals, the Swiss Confederates, only greatly exaggerated. As well as favouring broad flat hats crowned with large feathers and jerkins sporting puffed sleeves, the Landsknechts adopted hose with the legs of different colours and developed the custom of slashing their doublets open and pulling "puffs" of shirt through from underneath. A look that expressed arrogance and non-conformity, it became a major influence on Renaissance fashion.



Landsknecht captain
A mounted captain, holding a spear used for directing troops, addresses his bodyguard before battle.

Whether the Landsknechts were any wilder or more ungodly than the general run of fighting men in their period is hard to say. They were certainly much given to hard drink and gambling, which occupied the dead time out of combat. Many are known to have been killed in fights with their comrades rather than with the enemy, with luck at dice and cards often the source of the discord. Like all mercenary bands, they were liable to cause trouble when there was no war to provide them with an outlet for their energies and legitimate sources of plunder at the expense of the enemy. It was the failure of employers to pay them that provoked the most serious Landsknecht disturbances. The most infamous example was the sack of Rome in 1527. Unpaid Landsknechts mutinied from the army of Charles V, the Holy Roman Emperor, and went on the rampage, seeking to make up what they were owed through pillage. With other imperial troops (some 35,000 in all), they attacked and laid waste the city during a reign of terror that lasted nine months. The mercenaries refused to leave the city until they were paid their arrears of wages.

FIGHTING REGIMENTS

As fighting forces, the Landsknechts were at their peak in the early 16th century. From 1508, under the leadership of a German knight, Georg von Frundsberg, Emperor Maximilian I's Landsknechts were organized into a regiment more than 10,000 strong, which fought with distinction in a series of campaigns in Italy. But in these Italian wars there were often Landsknechts also fighting on the other side. Officially the Landsknechts were